



Francis of Assisi: The Boy Who Learned a New Family

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

A long time ago, in a hill town in Italy called Assisi, there lived a boy named Francis. His father sold cloth. His house had good food and fine clothes. Francis liked songs, parties, and shiny armor. He wanted to be a knight.

Then something changed. It did not change all at once, like a light turning on. It changed the way a seed grows — slowly, and then all at once you notice it. Francis stopped running from people he used to fear. He stopped clutching things. He started calling the sun his brother and the moon his sister. He walked across a war to talk instead of fight. When he was dying, he even called death a sister.

This booklet tells six stories from Francis's life. Each one has a story, words he really said (or words people who knew him wrote down), a big idea, something to try, and a question to ask a grown-up. The questions are not tests. They are doors.

Francis loved God. He loved Jesus. He loved people who were sick and people who were poor. He loved birds and water and fire. He did not worship the birds. He praised the God who made them. Keep that straight, and the stories stay true.

Chapter 1: The Thing That Tasted Bitter



Illustration for Chapter 1

Francis grew up behind stone walls. Assisi sat on a hill. Below the town, outside the walls, lived people nobody wanted to see. They had a terrible sickness. People called them lepers. The town said they must ring a bell so others could step away. Some people treated them as if they were already dead.

Francis was not a mean boy. He was a rich boy. He had been taught, without anyone needing to say it in a classroom, that a leper was something to fear. The sight of them, he later said, seemed too bitter.

He had already learned other hard things. He went to war with other young men of Assisi against a nearby city. He was captured. He spent a long time as a prisoner. He got sick. His father paid to bring him home. The parties did not taste the same after that.

One day the Lord led him among the people he most wanted to avoid. Francis did not write a long adventure story about it. He wrote only a few lines, near the end of his life, when he was trying to tell his brothers what had really started everything. He showed mercy. He did not stay on his horse and throw coins from a safe height. He came close.

When he left them, the bitterness had changed. It had become sweetness — in his soul, and in his body too. That is his own word: sweetness. Not a rule he learned. A taste that changed.

After that, Francis still lived in his father's house for a while. He still struggled. He visited the sick more often. He gave away more than his father liked. The seed had been planted. The rest of his life grew from that closeness, not from a fancy speech.

Notice what Francis does not say. He does not say, "I figured out a clever idea about kindness." He says the Lord led him. He says he showed mercy. He says the feeling in his body changed. Mercy, for him, was not a poster on a wall. It was hands and feet going where they did not want to go.

Umbria had leper houses outside the walls the way some towns have a dump — out of sight, out of mind. Law treated a leper as if life were already over: property gone, marriage ended, church doors shut. When Francis came close, he was not only being nice to a sick man. He was saying, without a speech, that this person still belonged to the human family.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: Francis did not begin by writing a book. He began by going toward a person he had been taught to fear.

Words to Remember

"When I was in sin, it seemed too bitter a thing to see lepers. And the Lord Himself led me among them and I showed mercy to them. And when I departed from them, what had seemed bitter to me was changed into sweetness of soul and body."

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— Francis, **Testament** (1226)

Plain English: Francis used to feel sick when he saw people everyone avoided. God led him close. Mercy changed the feeling.

Big Idea

A hard heart can change when a person moves toward someone they were taught to fear — not by pretending the fear isn't there, but by showing mercy anyway.

Try This

1. Draw two faces: "bitter" and "sweet." Under them, write one person or group you are shy of. Do not write a mean name. Write a kind one. 2. With a grown-up, choose one small kindness you can actually do this week for someone who is left out — a hello, a seat saved, a drawing given. 3. Act out getting off an imaginary horse. Practice slowing down instead of rushing past.

Ask a Grown-Up

Who taught you to be afraid of someone, and who taught you to come close?

Chapter 2: The Lady He Served

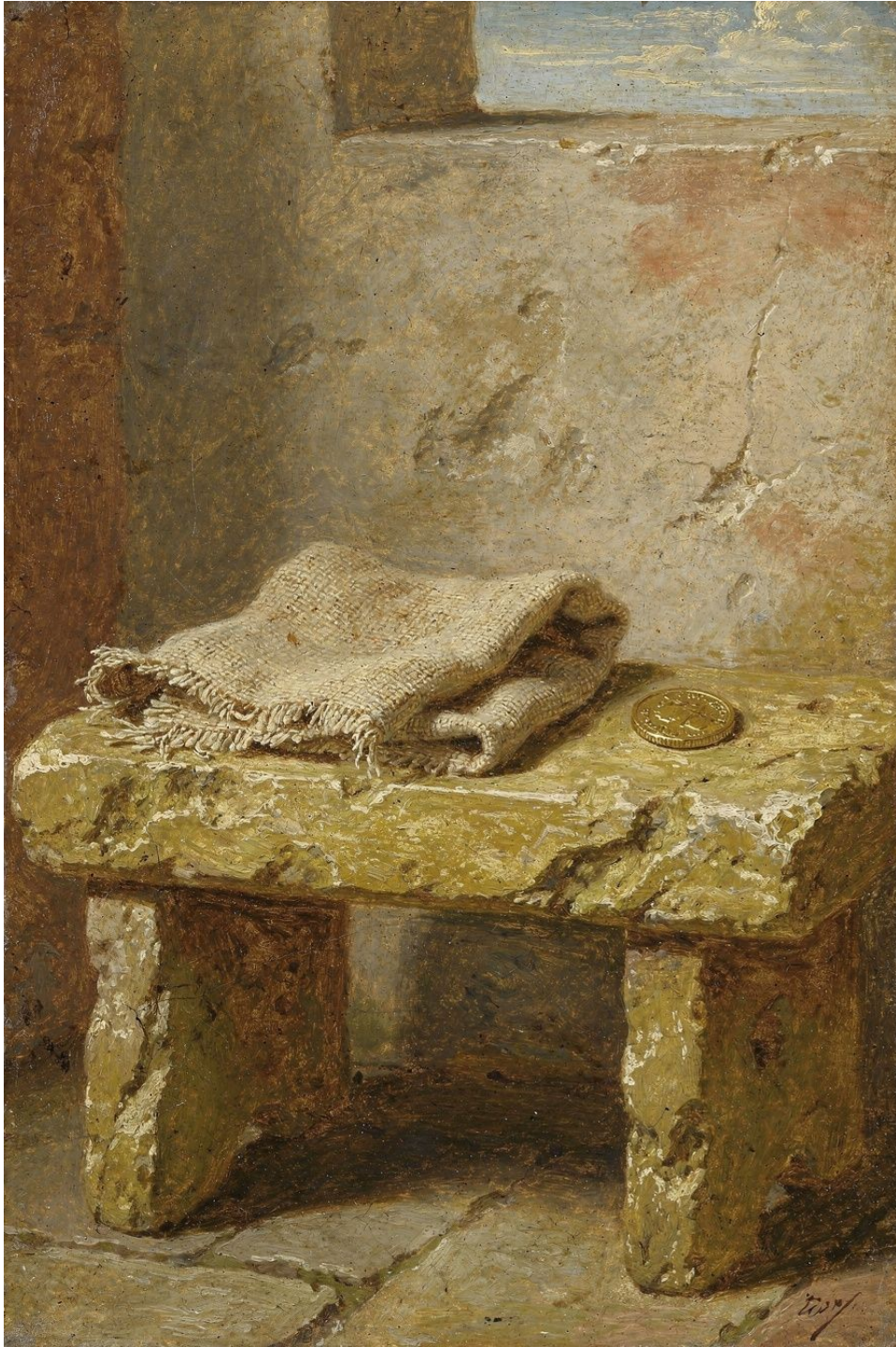


Illustration for Chapter 2

Francis's father, Pietro, sold cloth. Cloth was money you could wear. Fine fabric meant you belonged with the people who mattered in town. Francis had worn those clothes. He had wanted to be a knight, which also meant armor and a horse and a name people cheered.

After the leper, Francis started giving things away. He sold cloth that was not only his. His father was furious. This was not a small gift from extra coins. This was the shop walking out the door.

Francis had a strange way of talking about what he wanted instead. He did not say, "I would like fewer toys." He spoke as if poverty were a lady — Lady Poverty — the way singers in his time sang about a noble lady they would serve forever. Other young men sang about castles. Francis sang about having nothing to clutch.

Why? Because he believed Jesus was poor. Born in a place for animals. No house of his own. Dying with even his clothes taken. If God chose to be poor, Francis thought, then following God meant loosening your hands.

Poverty, for Francis, was not a contest to see who could be most miserable. He warned his brothers not to be proud of being poor. Pride in your old coat is still pride. He wanted to be free. If you own a pile of things, you spend your day guarding the pile. If you own nothing, you can look at people. You can look at God. You can work with your hands and, if you must, knock on a door and ask for bread.

He also wanted to be a brother, not a boss. People who own a lot often stand on a step above other people. Francis wanted the same step as everyone else — even lower. His brothers were called Friars Minor: lesser brothers.

He insisted they work. "I worked with my hands, and I still desire to work," he wrote near the end of his life. If they were not paid, they could ask for bread from door to door — "the Lord's table," he called it — but they were not to become professional idlers with a holy look on their faces.

One day, in the square of Assisi, the fight with his father came into the open. Francis took off the clothes that belonged to Pietro and gave them back. He said he now had a Father in heaven. The bishop covered him. It was a hard day for a family. It was the day Francis stopped pretending he could keep both the shop and the new life.

Words to Remember

"And let the brothers not appropriate anything to themselves, neither house nor place nor anything. And as pilgrims and strangers in this world, serving the Lord in poverty and humility, let them go with confidence to seek alms."

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— Francis, *Later Rule*, chapter 6

Plain English: Don't grab a house and call it yours. Live like a guest. If you must, ask for food.

Big Idea

Francis called poverty a lady he served because he wanted to be free to love God and people — not because he hated beautiful things, but because he did not want things to own him.

Try This

1. Pick one toy or extra shirt. With a grown-up, give it away for real. 2. Make a paper crown labeled "Lady Poverty." Write on it three things you can enjoy without buying them (sunlight, a song, a walk). 3. Work with your hands for twenty minutes: wash cups, sweep, fold. Francis wanted his brothers to work, not to be lazy.

Ask a Grown-Up

What do we own that owns our time — that we worry about more than we enjoy?

Chapter 3: Repair My House



Illustration for Chapter 3

Outside Assisi stood a little broken chapel called San Damiano. The roof was tired. The walls needed stones. Francis went there to pray. On the wall was a painted cross. The Christ in that painting does not look crumpled. His eyes are open. He looks alive.

Francis later wrote that the Lord gave him such faith in churches that he would pray a simple prayer in every one. The old stories say that while he prayed at San Damiano, he heard words from the cross: go and repair my house, which is falling down. Francis took the words the way a builder would. He carried stones. He begged for help. He even sold things to pay for repairs — which made his father angrier.

He also prayed a prayer that we still have, from those early days:

"Most High, glorious God, enlighten the darkness of my heart and give me true faith, certain hope, and perfect charity."

That is not a nature song. That is a young man asking God to fix the inside of him.

Friends began to gather. They did not start as a big organization with offices. They started as a small band who wanted to live the Gospel in a few words. Francis later wrote the sentence that still opens the Rule:

"The Rule and life of the Friars Minor is this: to observe the Holy Gospel of Our Lord Jesus Christ, living in obedience, without anything of one's own, and in chastity."

Chastity, for them, meant belonging to God with their whole lives, not grabbing people as if people were things.

Francis said no one showed him a plan. The Most High showed him to live according to the Holy Gospel. He had it written simply. A pope said yes. In churches he prayed another line he never got tired of:

"We adore You, Lord Jesus Christ, here and in all Your churches throughout the whole world, and we bless You, because by Your holy cross You have redeemed the world."

They worked with their hands. They preached with short, good words, not long showing-off sermons. They were not to touch money. They were to be lesser brothers, not greater ones.

Later the group grew huge. Rules had to get clearer. Francis worried the simple life would be explained away. Near the end of his life he told his brothers not to put a clever twist on the Rule — not to say, "What he really meant was..." He wanted the words kept simple. That fight would go on after he died. You do not need the whole fight yet. You need the first stone in Francis's hand, and the first friends walking with him.

San Damiano would later become a home for Clare, a woman of Assisi who wanted the same poor life. Francis did not do this work alone.

Words to Remember

"Most High, glorious God, enlighten the darkness of my heart and give me true faith, certain hope, and perfect charity, sense and knowledge, Lord, so that I may carry out Your holy and true command."

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— Francis, *Prayer before the Crucifix at San Damiano*

Plain English: God, light up the dark in me. Give me real faith, hope, and love, so I can do what you actually want.

Big Idea

Francis started by fixing a broken chapel. The bigger repair was a Church that had gotten rich and forgetful — and a heart that needed light.

Try This

1. With a grown-up, pick one real repair: a torn book, a wobbly chair, a messy corner of a church or classroom. Fix it with your hands. 2. Copy the San Damiano prayer in your own letters. Pray it once slowly. 3. Build a tiny chapel from blocks, then knock one wall down and rebuild it together. Talk about what "repair" means besides buildings.

Ask a Grown-Up

If someone said "repair my house" to our family, what house would we start with — our rooms, our church, or the way we treat people?

Chapter 4: Brother Sun, Sister Water



Illustration for Chapter 4

Francis did not think the world was God. He thought the world was God's. That little word 's matters.

When he was old, nearly blind, and very sick, he made a song in the language people actually spoke in Umbria — not only church Latin. We call it the Cantic of the Creatures, or the Cantic of Brother Sun. He praised God *through* the creatures, the way you might thank a cook through the taste of bread.

He called the sun Sir Brother Sun — beautiful, radiant, a likeness of the Most High, not the Most High himself. He called the moon and stars sisters. He thanked God through Brother Wind and every kind of weather. Sister Water was useful, humble, precious, and chaste — clean. Brother Fire was playful and strong. Sister Mother Earth feeds us with fruits, flowers, and herbs.

"Praised be You, my Lord, through Sister Water, which is very useful and humble and precious and chaste."

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"Praised be You, my Lord, through our Sister Mother Earth, who sustains and governs us, and who produces various fruits with colored flowers and herbs."

This is a family song. Families take care of each other. You do not kick your sister. You do not waste your brother. You do not pretend you made the sun.

Old stories say Francis preached to birds and picked worms off the road so they would not be stepped on. Some of those stories were written down later and grew like garden vines. The song itself is Francis's own. Start there. The song is enough to teach the idea: everything made is a sibling in God's house, and people are not the only ones who get to praise.

In 1223, at a place called Greccio, Francis asked for a live manger scene — real animals, real straw — so people could see that God came into a real world, not a pretend one. Christmas, for him, belonged with hay and breath and cold air.

If someone tells you Francis was only an animal saint who forgot Jesus, they have not read the song carefully. The first words are "Most High, all-powerful, good Lord." The creatures come after. They come as family. They do not climb onto the throne.

He even praised God through weather that is not pretty — cloudy air as well as serene air — because creatures need that weather to live. Kindness to Sister Earth is not only hugging trees. It is noticing that we are guests on soil that feeds us.

Words to Remember

"Praised be You, my Lord, with all Your creatures, especially Sir Brother Sun, who is the day and through whom You give us light. And he is beautiful and radiant with great splendor; and bears a likeness of You, Most High One."

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— Francis, **Canticle of the Creatures**

Plain English: Thank you, God, together with everything you made — especially the sun, who looks a little like your brightness, but is not you.

Big Idea

Francis loved the world because God made it. He called sun and water brother and sister so we would take care of them — not so we would bow down to them.

Try This

1. Go outside. Name five things the way Francis would: Brother Wind, Sister Water, and so on. Draw them as a family portrait with God as the one they praise. 2. Do one care-job: fill a birdbath, pick up litter, water a plant, turn off a dripping tap. 3. Sing or speak three lines of the Canticle at dinner.

Ask a Grown-Up

If water is a sister, what is one way our house is kind to her — and one way we are not?

Chapter 5: The Lord Give You Peace

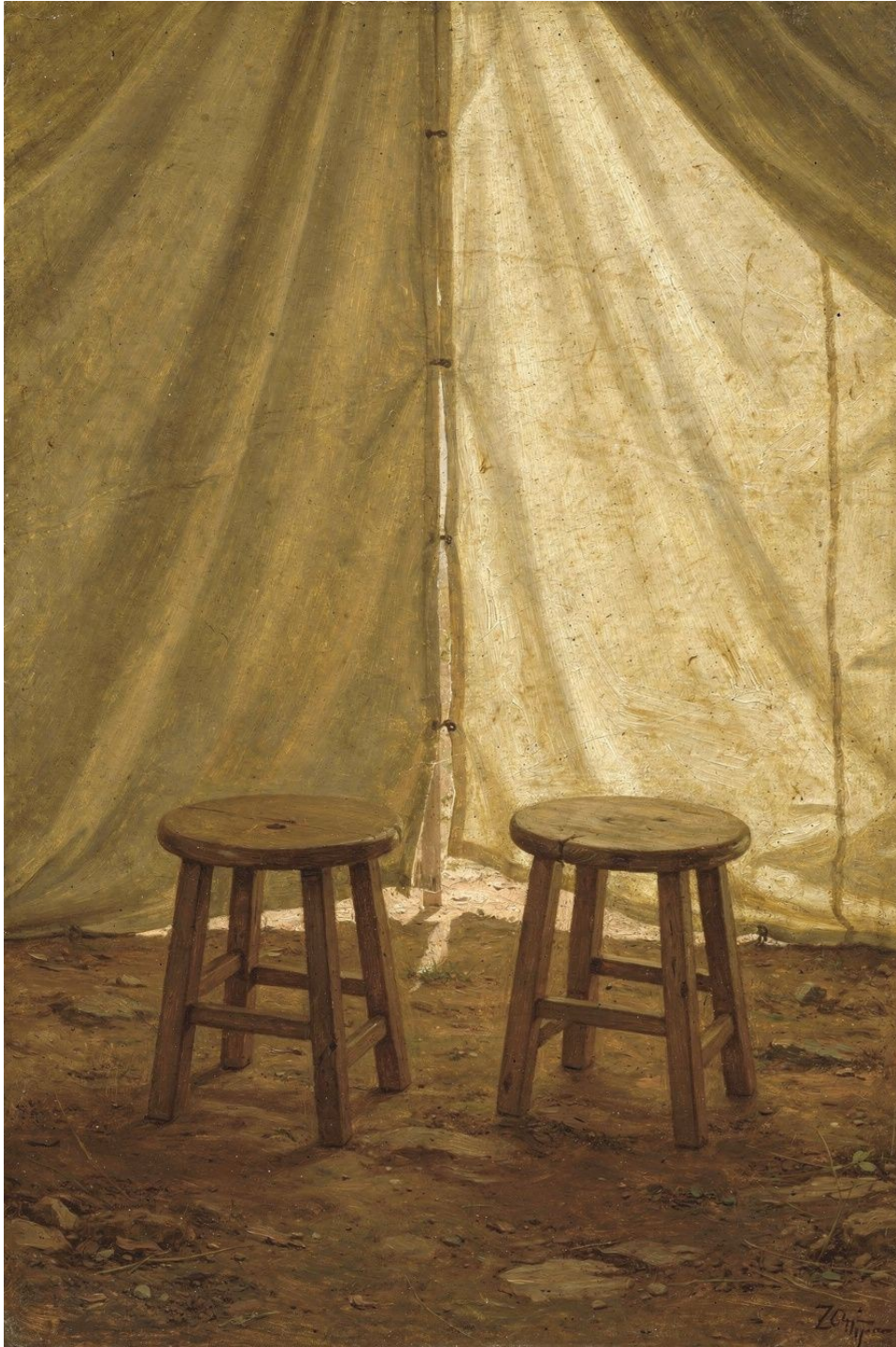


Illustration for Chapter 5

Francis taught his brothers a greeting: "The Lord give you peace." He said the Lord showed him to say it. He had not used it before.

In his town, greetings could be like little ladders. You spoke one way to a rich man and another way to a servant. Francis's greeting was the same for everyone. It wished them a gift nobody could buy.

He also added lines to his Canticle when Assisi's bishop and the city leader were fighting. He sent brothers to sing them in front of both men:

"Praised be You, my Lord, through those who give pardon for Your love, and bear infirmity and tribulation. Blessed are those who endure in peace, for by You, Most High, shall they be crowned."

The song was not only about weather. It was about making up. Pardon, in that verse, is not cheap. The people who pardon also bear trouble. Peace is a crown, not a nap.

Francis wrote to a leader in his order that if a brother fell into sin a thousand times, he should be received back. That is a hard kind of peace. It is not pretending nothing happened. It is refusing to throw a person away.

The bravest peace story is from a war. In 1219, during a crusade in Egypt, Christian soldiers were attacking a city called Damietta. Francis did not like what he saw in the camp — men fighting for loot more than for God. He and a brother named Illuminatus crossed toward the Muslim camp. They could have been killed. They were beaten and brought to the Sultan, al-Kamil.

We do not have a tape recording of their talk. The earliest writer says the Sultan listened with great attention and was kind. Francis did not make the Sultan a Christian. The Sultan did not make Francis a soldier. Francis refused gifts and was sent back alive. Later tales added fire-walking and secret baptisms. Those later tales are not the solid center. The solid center is: he went, he talked, he came back.

Francis still believed Jesus is Lord. He did not pretend all religions are the same song. He also refused to treat the man on the other side as a monster. Both things can be true at once. That is grown-up, even for children to begin learning.

The Rule for going among Muslims said brothers might live quietly among them, subject to them for God's sake, or, if it pleased God, announce the word of God. Francis chose to speak. He did not choose a sword.

A famous prayer that starts "Lord, make me an instrument of your peace" is beautiful. It is not from Francis. It showed up hundreds of years later. We do not hang it on him. We keep his real greeting instead.

Words to Remember

"And the Lord revealed to me that I should say the greeting, 'The Lord give you peace,' which I previously did not use."

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— Francis, **Testament**

Plain English: God taught me a hello: peace from the Lord — for everybody, not just my friends.

Big Idea

Peace, for Francis, was something you do: the same greeting for all, pardon that costs, and walking toward an enemy to talk.

Try This

1. For one day, greet people with "Peace" (or "The Lord give you peace" if that fits your house). Notice how it feels. 2. Practice a repair conversation with stuffed animals: name the hurt, say sorry, ask to start again. 3. Draw two camps with a river between them. Draw Francis walking across. Write one sentence he might have said that is not a shout and not a lie.

Ask a Grown-Up

When is talking to someone we disagree with brave, and when is it unwise — and how do we tell?

Chapter 6: Sister Bodily Death



Illustration for Chapter 6

Francis got sicker and sicker. His eyes hurt. His body was tired from years of hard living. In 1224, on a mountain called La Verna, while he was praying about Jesus on the cross, something happened that his friends never forgot. Marks like nail wounds showed on his

hands and feet, and a wound in his side. The brothers who cared for him saw them. Francis tried to hide them with gloves and shoes. He did not show them off.

People still argue about how those marks came. This booklet will not pretend we have a doctor's chart from 1224. What we can say without guessing: Francis spent his life trying to be like Jesus, especially Jesus who loved and suffered. At the end, his body carried signs of that love. His friends treated the marks as real.

Near death, at a little place called the Portiuncula, he added the last verse to his Cantic. He praised God through Sister Bodily Death, from whom no living person escapes. He warned that dying turned away from God is a true grief. He blessed those whom death finds in God's will. Then he asked his brothers to sing.

He had written a tiny blessing for Brother Leo on a scrap of parchment, in his own hand — the only writing we still have in Francis's handwriting: "Blessing and all good, the Lord give you. Brother Francis." He could have signed "master." He signed "brother."

He also wrote praises that sound like a list of who God is: "You are love, You are wisdom, You are humility, You are patience." Humility sits in that list as if it belongs to God, not only to shy people. That is how Francis thought: God is not a bully on a cloud. God is the Most High who chose a manger and a cross.

Francis died on the night of October 3, 1226. People still tell extra stories that grew later, like fairy-tale vines. Some are lovely. They are not the same as his own words. His own words are enough: mercy that turned bitter to sweet, a Rule in few words, a song to Brother Sun, a greeting of peace, and a last praise through Sister Death.

After him came Clare, who kept the poor life with the sisters. Came Bonaventure, who thought hard about how creation shows God. Came a poet named Dante, who put Francis in a high song in heaven. Came, many centuries later, a pope who took the name Francis and wrote *Laudato Si'* — "Praised be" — from the Cantic. The family kept singing. You can learn that song without pretending you are a saint, and without turning Francis into a cartoon bird-man.

A last picture: Francis asked to be laid on the ground near the end, as if even his dying body should not clutch a bed as property. Whether every later detail of that scene is exact, the meaning matches the man we do have in writing. Hands open. Brother, not master. Praise until the last verse is sung. The brothers who were there sang the Cantic as he died. That is how a poor man finishes a song.

Words to Remember

"Praised be You, my Lord, through our Sister Bodily Death, from whom no living man can escape. ... Blessed are those whom death will find in Your most holy will, for the second death shall do them no harm."

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— Francis, **Canticle of the Creatures** (last verse)

Plain English: Even dying can be praised as part of God's family, if we belong to God. Francis is not saying dying is a joke. He is saying we do not have to treat it as a stranger.

Big Idea

Francis ended the way he began: not owning the last word, but praising God with the family of creatures — even with death as a sister.

Try This

1. Make a seven-box comic: leper, clothes in the square, stones at San Damiano, Canticle, peace greeting, Sultan, Sister Death. One sentence under each box. 2. Write a one-line blessing for someone, like Brother Leo's, and give it. 3. Light a candle (with a grown-up) and thank God for one person who has died whom your family loves. Keep it simple. No spooky games.

Ask a Grown-Up

What song or prayer do we want at the end of a life — and why does Francis's "sister" language help or not help?

For the Grown-Up Reader

The stories follow Francis's own writings as translated in Armstrong and Brady, *Francis and Clare: The Complete Works* (Paulist Press, 1982): the *Testament*, the Later Rule, the Prayer before the Crucifix, the Canticle, the greeting of peace, the Letter to a Minister ("if he should fall a thousand times"), and the Blessing of Brother Leo. San Damiano's voice from the crucifix and the Sultan's "great attention" come from Thomas of Celano's *Vita Prima* (1228), written while witnesses were alive. Augustine Thompson's *Francis of Assisi: A New Biography* (2012) is the modern historical check.

Little-band edges: this booklet does not give children the "Peace Prayer" (a modern text, not Francis). It does not treat the later *Fioretti* wolf as history. It does not turn Francis into a pantheist or a cartoon. Stigmata are told as marks his brothers saw; the medical argument

waits for older bands. The poverty fight after his death (Spirituals and Conventuals) is named only as a worry he already felt, not as a courtroom.

Did he really say these things? The Canticle, Testament, Rules, and prayers are his. Celano is early and not magic. Later legends are labeled as later.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge produces four age-adapted booklets for each figure: elementary (ages 5–10), middle (ages 11–14), high (ages 15–18), and adult. Each booklet covers the same person, ideas, and stories, but at a different level of depth and complexity. The elementary booklet tells stories. The middle booklet explains ideas. The high booklet argues and analyzes. The adult booklet engages with scholarly debates and primary sources. Read the one that fits — or read them all and watch the same figure grow.